‘Console her,’ I said. And he left, sobbing.

That night Subhash asked me if I wanted a drink. I felt like having one, but wasn’t sure. When I returned from the rest room, I found a pint of rum under my pillow. I returned the bottle unopened to Subhash the next morning. I have not been a heavy drinker, but have enjoyed an occasional whiskey.

HOW WE CANNIBALISED A ROLLS ROYCE LAB

‘You eye liquid stuff anywhere you go,’ Sarabhai said, ‘and now you have got something too.’

When SEP decided to upgrade the M-40 liquid engine to a 60-tonner, I knew it was our best opportunity to strike a deal with France to be part of the project and learn in the process. I kept pestering Grover to push for it and he continued to impress Souffle and Rene Morin. It was late 1971, months before Sarabhai’s death. I kept telling Sarabhai that we should not let go of the opportunity.

The process was set in motion by my visit to Paris, and P Souffle and Morin coming down to India. While this was on, Sarabhai got news that the UK, which then had a fledgling yet promising space programme was winding it up after the US impressed upon it that it was duplicating efforts and, as a natural ally, the US could launch British satellites.

The UK had begun its space programme in 1957, and its Ariel series of satellites, starting with Ariel 1 in 1962, were launched by the US. The British embarked on an ambitious project to develop a satellite launch vehicle in 1957, but the project called Black Prince had to be shelved three years later for want of funds. They, however, put together a rocket called Black Arrow, which launched the Prospero satellite from Woomera, Australia in 1971. Black Arrow had three failures since 1969, before putting Prespero in a low earth orbit. Prospero, which studied the effects of the space environment on satellites, remains the only British satellite to be